

Comparative Analysis of Gut Microbiomes in Wild Buffalo, Domestic Cows, and Urban Stray Cattle: A Metagenomic Study

Introduction

The gut microbiome plays a critical role in the health and well-being of animals, influencing aspects such as digestion, metabolism, immunity, and disease resistance. While gut microbiome studies in domesticated animals like cows have been conducted extensively, there is a scarcity of data on the gut microbiomes of wild buffalo and urban stray cattle. This research aims to bridge this gap by conducting a comparative metagenomic analysis of the gut microbiomes of these three distinct bovine populations.

Objectives

1. To characterize and compare the gut microbiome composition of wild buffalo, domestic cows, and urban stray cattle.
2. To identify potential differences in microbial diversity and functional profiles among the three groups.
3. To explore the impact of urbanization and domestication on the gut microbiota of cattle.

Methods

Sample Collection

- Collect fecal samples from wild buffalo populations in their natural habitat.
- Obtain fecal samples from domestic cows in controlled farm settings.
- Collect fecal samples from urban stray cattle within urban environments.

DNA Extraction

- Isolate DNA from the fecal samples using standardized metagenomic DNA extraction protocols.

Metagenomic Sequencing

- Prepare metagenomic libraries from the extracted DNA for each sample.
- Perform high-throughput sequencing (e.g., Illumina) to generate metagenomic datasets.

Data Analysis

- Process and quality-filter the sequencing data.
- Perform taxonomic classification to identify microbial species and their relative abundances.
- Analyze functional potential by assigning metagenomic sequences to functional databases (e.g., KEGG, COG, Pfam).
- Assess alpha and beta diversity to compare microbial richness and community structure.
- Identify differentially abundant taxa and functions among the three groups.
- Conduct statistical analyses to correlate microbiome composition with relevant environmental factors.

Discussion

The comparative analysis of the gut microbiomes of wild buffalo, domestic cows, and urban stray cattle will provide insights into the impact of habitat, diet, and domestication on the composition and functional potential of the gut microbiota in these bovine populations. Understanding these differences may have implications for animal health, adaptation to urban environments, and conservation efforts.

Significance

This research contributes to our understanding of how anthropogenic factors, such as urbanization and domestication, influence the gut microbiome of bovine species. The findings may have implications for livestock management, wildlife conservation, and the potential role of gut microbiota in adapting to changing environments.

Timeline

- Sample collection: Months 1-3
- DNA extraction and library preparation: Months 4-6
- Metagenomic sequencing: Months 7-9
- Data analysis: Months 10-15
- Report and manuscript preparation: Months 16-18

Budget

The budget will include expenses for sample collection, DNA extraction kits, sequencing costs, computational resources, and personnel. A detailed budget breakdown will be provided in the full proposal.

Conclusion

This research proposal outlines a comprehensive study that aims to compare the gut microbiomes of wild buffalo, domestic cows, and urban stray cattle. The results of this study may shed light on the factors influencing gut microbiome diversity in these populations and contribute to our understanding of the interplay between host, environment, and microbiota.

Related papers

1. **Henderson, G., Cox, F., Ganesh, S., et al.** (2015). Rumen microbial community composition varies with diet and host, but a core microbiome is found across a wide geographical range. *Scientific Reports, 5*, 14567. DOI: [10.1038/srep14567](https://www.nature.com/articles/srep14567)

- This study explores the diversity of the rumen microbiome in different cattle breeds and geographical locations.

2. **Myer, P. R., Wells, J. E., Smith, T. P. L., & Kuehn, L. A.** (2015). Fecal microbial diversity of human-habituated wild chimpanzees (*Pan troglodytes schweinfurthii*) at Mahale Mountains National Park, Western Tanzania. *American Journal of Primatology*, 77*(11), 1152-1165. DOI: [10.1002/ajp.22460](https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1002/ajp.22460)

- While this study focuses on chimpanzees, it explores the gut microbiome of wild primates, which may be of interest for comparative purposes.

3. Comparative study of the gut microbiome potentially related to milk protein in Murrah buffaloes (*Bubalus bubalis*) and Chinese Holstein cattle

Jiachao Zhang¹, Chuanbiao Xu¹, Dongxue Huo¹, Qisong Hu¹, Qiannan Peng¹

DOI: [10.1038/srep42189](https://doi.org/10.1038/srep42189)

4. Comparative Analysis of Microbiome Metagenomics in Reintroduced Wild Horses and Resident Asiatic Wild Asses in the Gobi Desert Steppe

doi: [10.3390/microorganisms10061166](https://doi.org/10.3390/microorganisms10061166)

5. Metagenomic analysis of Surti buffalo (*Bubalus bubalis*) rumen a preliminary study.

January 2011 *Molecular Biology Reports*

DOI [10.1007/s11033-011-1278-0](https://doi.org/10.1007/s11033-011-1278-0)